

Feathers

Birds have spread to every continent on Earth, partly because of their ability to fly. Feathers play a vital role in their flight, and help birds to stay warm, attract mates, and be camouflaged. Feathers come in many shapes and sizes, and have different functions.

WHAT ARE FEATHERS FOR?

Feathers allow flight, keep birds warm, provide camouflage, and help attract a mate. In many nesting birds, an area of feathers moults to allow more heat to pass from the mother bird to the eggs.



FLIGHT
Stiff wing and tail feathers aid flight.



TEMPERATURE CONTROL
Downy base of feather traps air for warmth.



ATTRACTION
Bright colours can help attract a mate.



CAMOUFLAGE
Patterns help bird blend into background.

TYPES OF FEATHERS

Birds have two main types of feathers: down feathers for warmth, and contour feathers for flight. The feathers grow in areas called tracts, with bare skin in between. The bare areas are hidden by the feathers.

PRIMARIES
These are flight feathers, attached to the front section of the wing.

TAIL FEATHERS
For balance, braking, and elevating in flight.

GAME BIRDS

Game birds spend most of their time on the ground, preferring to walk rather than fly. Their flight feathers have a very pronounced curve, or camber, to provide explosive lift and quick bursts of flight.



PARROTS AND COCKATOOS

Parrots use their brightly coloured feathers to attract the opposite sex. The vivid colours may also help disguise these birds against the vibrant green of the forests where they live.



TOUCANS AND WOODPECKERS

Woodpeckers and toucans do not have any soft down feathers, even when they are chicks.



BIRDS OF PREY

There are two families of birds of prey: falcon-like birds that are awake in the daytime, and owls that are awake at night. Some can soar for hours to look for food, others achieve great speed when they dive down to catch their prey.



COLOURFUL DISPLAY

Male peacocks have amazingly colourful tail feathers that spread up and around into a fan shape behind them when they want to attract a mate. The females choose a mate depending on how many eye spots are on his tail – the more the better.

